Lesson 25 material: Body Paragraphs

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

4.5: Writing Body Paragraphs

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Learning Objectives

1. Select primary support related to your thesis.
2. Support your topic sentences.
3. Providing connections between thesis and body paragraphs.

If your thesis and outline give the reader a roadmap to your essay, then body paragraphs should closely follow that map. The reader should be able to predict what follows your introductory paragraph by simply reading the thesis statement. Using transition words helps in connecting ideas for your reader and creates coherence. See Chapter 5 for chart of effective transitions.

The body paragraphs present the evidence you have gathered to confirm your thesis. Before you begin to support your thesis in the body, you must find information from a variety of sources that support and give credit to what you are trying to prove.

Primary Support for Your Thesis

Without primary support, your argument is not likely to be convincing. Primary support can be described as the major points you choose to expand on your thesis. It is the most important information you select to argue for your point of view. Each point you choose will be incorporated into the topic sentence for each body paragraph you write. Your primary supporting points are further supported by supporting details within the paragraphs.

Identify the Characteristics of Good Primary Support

In order to fulfill the requirements of good primary support, the information you choose must meet the following standards:

- **Be specific.** The main points you make about your thesis and the examples you use to expand on those points need to be specific. Use specific examples to provide the evidence and to build upon your general ideas. These types of examples give your reader something narrow to focus on, and if used properly, they leave little doubt about your claim. General examples, while they convey the necessary information, are not nearly as compelling or useful in writing because they are too obvious and typical.
- **Be relevant to the thesis.** Primary support is considered strong when it relates directly to the thesis. Primary support should show, explain, or prove your main argument without delving into irrelevant details. When faced with lots of information that could be used to prove your thesis, you may think you need to include it all in your body paragraphs. But effective writers resist the temptation to lose focus. Choose your examples wisely by making sure they directly connect to your thesis.
- **Be detailed.** Remember that your thesis, while specific, should not be very detailed. The body paragraphs are where you develop the discussion that a thorough essay requires. Using detailed support shows readers that you have considered all the facts and chosen only the most precise details to enhance your point of view.

Prewrite to Identify Primary Supporting Points for a Thesis Statement

Recall that when you prewrite you essentially make a list of examples or reasons why you support your stance. Stemming from each point, you further provide details to support those reasons. After prewriting, you are then able to look back at the information and choose the most compelling pieces you will use in your body paragraphs.

Exercise :

Choose one of the following working thesis statements. On a separate sheet of paper, write for at least five minutes using one of the prewriting techniques you learned in this chapter.

1. Unleashed dogs on city streets are a dangerous nuisance.
2. Students cheat for many different reasons.
3. Drug use among teens and young adults is a problem.
4. The most important change that should occur at my college or university is _____.

Select the Most Effective Primary Supporting Points for a Thesis Statement

After you have prewritten about your working thesis statement, you may have generated a lot of information, which may be edited out later. Remember that your primary support must be relevant to your thesis. Remind yourself of your main argument, and delete any ideas that do not directly relate to it. Omitting unrelated ideas ensures that you will use only the most convincing information in your body paragraphs. Choose at least three of only the most compelling points. These will serve as the topic sentences for your body paragraphs.

Exercise :

Refer to the previous exercise and select three of your most compelling reasons to support the thesis statement. Remember that the points you choose must be specific and relevant to the thesis. The statements you choose will be your primary support points, and you will later incorporate them into the topic sentences for the body paragraphs. You may also choose to outline your reasons, as part of your pre-writing.

Using Evidence to Support Your Thesis

When you support your thesis, you are revealing evidence. Evidence includes anything that can help support your stance. The following are the kinds of evidence you will encounter as you conduct your research:

1. **Facts.** Facts are the best kind of evidence to use because they often cannot be disputed. They can support your stance by providing background information on or a solid foundation for your point of view. However, some facts may still need explanation. For example, the sentence "The most populated state in the United States is California" is a pure fact, but it may require some explanation to make it relevant to your specific argument.
2. **Judgments.** Judgments are conclusions drawn from the given facts. Judgments are more credible than opinions because they are founded upon careful reasoning and examination of a topic.
3. **Testimony.** Testimony consists of direct quotations from either an eyewitness or an expert witness. An eyewitness is someone who has direct experience with a subject; he adds authenticity to an argument based on facts. An expert witness is a person who has extensive experience with a topic. This person studies the facts and provides commentary based on either facts or judgments, or both. An expert witness adds authority and credibility to an argument.
4. **Personal observation.** Personal observation is similar to testimony, but personal observation consists of your testimony. It reflects what you know to be true because you have experiences and have formed either opinions or judgments about them. For instance, if you are one of five children and your thesis states that being part of a large family is beneficial to a child's social development, you could use your own experience to support your thesis.

Choose Supporting Topic Sentences

Each body paragraph contains a topic sentence that states one aspect of your thesis and then expands upon it. Like the thesis statement, each topic sentence should be specific and supported by concrete details, facts, or explanations.

Each body paragraph should comprise the following elements:

topic sentence + supporting details (examples, reasons, or arguments)

As you read earlier, topic sentences indicate the location and main points of the basic arguments of your essay. These sentences are vital to writing your body ragraphs because they always refer back to and support your thesis statement. Topic sentences are linked to the ideas you have introduced in your thesis, thus reminding readers what your essay is about. A paragraph without a clearly identified topic sentence may be unclear and scattered, just like an essay without a thesis statement.

Tip

Unless your teacher instructs otherwise, you should include at least three body paragraphs in your essay. A five-paragraph essay, including the introduction and conclusion, is commonly the standard for exams and essay assignments. It is not, however, the only format for an academic essay. It is, perhaps, the most familiar one.

Draft Supporting Detail Sentences for Each Primary Support Sentence

After deciding which primary support points you will use as your topic sentences, you must add details to clarify and demonstrate each of those points. These supporting details provide examples, facts, or evidence that support the topic sentence.

The writer drafts possible supporting detail sentences for each primary support sentence based on the thesis statement:

Figure

Tip

You have the option of writing your topic sentences in one of three ways. You can state it at thebeginning of the body paragraph, or at the end of the paragraph, or you do not have to write it at all. This is called an implied topic sentence. An implied topic sentence lets readers form the main idea for themselves. For beginning writers, it is best to not use implied topic sentences because it makes it harder to focus your writing. Your instructor may also want to clearly identify the sentences that support your thesis.

Print out the first draft of your essay and use a highlighter to mark your topic sentences in the body paragraphs. Make sure they are clearly stated and accurately present your paragraphs, as well as accurately reflect your thesis. If your topic sentence contains information that does not exist in the rest of the paragraph, rewrite it to more accurately match the rest of the paragraph.

Key Takeaways

- Your body paragraphs should closely follow the path set forth by your thesis statement.
- Strong body paragraphs contain evidence that supports your thesis.
- Primary support comprises the most important points you use to support your thesis.
- Strong primary support is specific, detailed, and relevant to the thesis.
- Prewriting helps you determine your most compelling primary support.
- Evidence includes facts, judgments, testimony, and personal observation.
- Reliable sources may include newspapers, magazines, academic journals, books, encyclopedias, and firsthand testimony.
- A topic sentence presents one point of your thesis statement while the information in the rest of the paragraph supports that point.
- A body paragraph comprises a topic sentence plus supporting details.

4.6: More About the Basic Elements of a First Draft

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

If you have been using the information in this chapter step by step to help you develop an assignment, you may already have a topic outline to direct your writing. Knowing what a first draft looks like will help you make the creative leap from the outline to the first draft. A first draft should include the following elements:

- An introduction that piques the audience's interest, tells what the essay is about, and motivates readers to keep reading.
- A *thesis statement* that presents the main point, or controlling idea, of the entire piece of writing.
- A topic sentence in each paragraph that states the main idea of the paragraph and implies how that main idea connects to the thesis statement.
- Supporting sentences in each paragraph that develop or explain the topic sentence. These can be specific facts, examples, anecdotes, or other details that elaborate on the topic sentence.
- A conclusion that reinforces the thesis statement and leaves the audience with a feeling of completion.

These elements follow the standard five-paragraph essay format, which you probably first encountered in high school. This basic format is valid for most essays you will write in college, even much longer ones.

The Role of Topic Sentences

Topic sentences make the structure of a text and the writer's basic arguments easy to locate and comprehend. In college writing, using a topic sentence in each paragraph of the essay is the standard rule. However, the topic sentence does not always have to be the first sentence in your paragraph even if it the first item in your formal outline.

The topic sentence can be the first, middle, or final sentence in a paragraph. The assignment's audience and purpose will often determine where a topic sentence belongs.When the purpose of the assignment is to persuade, for example, the topic sentence should be the first sentence in a paragraph. In a persuasive essay, the writer's point of view should be clearly expressed at the beginning of each paragraph.

Choosing where to position the topic sentence depends not only on your audience and purpose but also on the essay's arrangement, or order. When you organize information according to order of importance, the topic sentence may be the final sentence in a paragraph. All the supporting sentences build up to the topic sentence. Chronological order may also position the topic sentence as the final sentence because the controlling idea of the paragraph may make the most sense at the end of a sequence.

When you organize information according to spatial order, a topic sentence may appear as the middle sentence in a paragraph. An essay arranged by spatial order often contains paragraphs that begin with descriptions. A reader may first need a visual in his or her mind before understanding the development of the paragraph. When the topic sentence is in the middle, it unites the details that come before it with the ones that come after it.

Tip

When you begin to draft your paragraphs, you should follow your outline fairly closely. After all, you spent valuable time developing those ideas. However, as you begin to express your ideas in complete sentences, it might strike you that the topic sentence might work better at the end of the paragraph or in the middle. Try it. Writing a draft, by its nature, is a good time for experimentation.

As you read critically throughout the writing process, keep topic sentences in mind. Developing topic sentences and thinking about their placement in a paragraph will prepare you to write the rest of the paragraph.

The Role of Paragraphs

The paragraph is the main structural component of an essay as well as other forms of writing. Each paragraph of an essay adds another related main idea to support the writer's thesis, or controlling idea. Each related main idea is supported and developed with facts, examples, and other details that explain it. By exploring and refining one main idea at a time, writers build a strong case for their thesis.

Students often ask the question:"How long should a paragraph be?" One answer to this important question may be "long enough" — long enough for you to address your points and explain your main idea. To grab attention or to present succinct supporting ideas, a paragraph can be fairly short and consist of two to three sentences. A paragraph in a complex essay about some abstract point in philosophy or archaeology can be three-quarters of a page or more in length. As long as the writer maintains close focus on the topic and does not ramble, a long paragraph is acceptable in college-level writing. In general, try to keep the paragraphs longer than one sentence but shorter than one full page of double-spaced text.

Journalistic style often calls for brief two-or three-sentence paragraphs because of how people read the news, both online and in print. Blogs and other online information sources often adopt this paragraphing style, too. Readers often skim the first paragraphs of a great many articles before settling on the handful of stories they want to read in detail.

You may find that a particular paragraph you write may be longer than one that will hold your audience's interest. In such cases, you should divide the paragraph into two or more shorter paragraphs, adding a topic statement or some kind of transitional word or phrase at the start of the new paragraph. Transition words or phrases show the connection between the two ideas.

In all cases, however, be guided by what your instructor wants and expects to find in your draft. Many instructors will expect you to develop a mature college-level style as you progress through the semester's assignments.

Starting Your First Draft

Now we are finally ready to look over Tuyet's shoulder as she begins to write her essay about digital technology and the confusing choices that consumers face. As she does, you should have in front of you your outline, with its thesis statement and topic sentences, and the notes you wrote earlier in this lesson on your purpose and audience. Reviewing these will put both you and Tuyet in the proper mind-set to start.

The following is Tuyet's thesis statement:

Everyone wants the newest and the best digital technology, but the choices are many, and the specifications are often confusing

Here are the notes that Tuyet wrote to herself to characterize her purpose and audience:

Figure

Tuyet chose to begin by writing a quick introduction based on her thesis statement. She knew that she would want to improve her introduction significantly when she revised. Right now, she just wanted to give herself a starting point. You will read her introduction again in the chapter on "Revising and Editing" when she revises it.

With her thesis statement and her purpose and audience notes in front of her, Tuyet then looked at her outline. She chose to use that outline because it includes the topic sentences. The following is the portion of her outline of one of her body paragraphs. The roman numeral II identifies the topic sentence for the paragraph, capital letters indicate supporting details, and Arabic numerals label subpoints.

Figure

Tuyet then began to expand the ideas in her outline into a paragraph. Notice how the outline helped her guarantee that all her sentences in the body of the paragraph develop the topic sentence.

Figure

In your documents, observe any formatting requirements—for margins, headers, placement of page numbers, and other layout matters—that your instructor requires.

Continuing the First Draft

Tuyet continued writing her essay, moving to the second and third body paragraphs. She had supporting details but no numbered subpoints in her outline, so she had to consult her prewriting notes for specific information to include. Then she began to write the conclusion of her paper.

2.5: Writing Body Paragraphs

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

The parts of a body paragraph

Body paragraphs support and develop your thesis statement. Each body paragraph should focus on one point, which is usually communicated at the beginning of the paragraph in the form of a **topic sentence**. A strong body paragraph should also contain **supporting evidence**, **analysis** showing how this evidence connects to your topic sentence and thesis statement and, finally, a **concluding sentence**.

Noticing the structure of a body paragraph

Let's look at a sample body paragraph and evaluate how effective it is.

Notice this!

Read the following body paragraph. As you read, think about how the body paragraph does or doesn't fit with our definition above. The thesis statement for this essay is, "The problem with stereotypes is not that they are untrue, but that they are incomplete, and make one story become the only story."

Adichie argues that a single story usually provides only one part of a story: just one negative or positive side of a person, yet this becomes their label or their definition. Adichie cites the example of Modupe Akinola, a female African-American professor. When she began teaching at Columbia Business School, students often asked her when the professor would arrive because she did not fit the stereotype of what a professor should look like in the U.S. Stereotypes are "incomplete" and can lead to prejudice as Adichie points out in her TED talk. Due to a lack of exposure, Akinola's students were probably expecting to see an old white male or possibly a white female professor instead of a young African-American female professor. Also, because of the angry black female stereotype (Eberhardt), during lectures, this may lead students to read Akinola's facial expressions in an incorrect way which may cause confusion.

If you found the paragraph a little confusing, you aren't alone (see figure 2.5.1)! For example, this paragraph lacks a clear topic sentence; this makes it more difficult for both readers and the writer of the essay to get a clear grasp of the paragraph's purpose. The supporting evidence also isn't sufficiently introduced, and there's no clear concluding sentence.

(Picture: Woman holding a book and looking confused)

Figure: "Confused" by CollegeDegrees360 is marked with CC BY-SA 2.0.

Let's explore each element of a strong body paragraph in further detail. Then, we'll come back to this paragraph about stereotypes.

Topic sentences

Each body paragraph should begin with a topic sentence that is directly related to and supportive of your thesis statement. The topic sentence should be an opinion statement and should introduce the main idea of the body paragraph. All of the sentences in the rest of the paragraph should relate to, support, and expand on the topic sentence. Here are some guidelines to keep in mind when writing a topic sentence:

- The topic sentence is usually the first sentence of a body paragraph
- Like a thesis statement, a topic sentence should be arguable and specific
- A topic sentence should be clear, to-the-point, and in your own words (in general, avoid starting the topic sentence with a quotation or paraphrase)
- A topic sentence can also help the reader transition from one idea in the previous paragraph to the next by referring to a previous idea

Another way to think about it is this: A topic sentence expresses both the topic and controlling idea of a body paragraph. This means that the topic sentence of a body paragraph goes beyond just stating the topic, but also shows the writer's perspective on the subject.

Read the following topic sentence examples.

- In the STEM field, stereotypes persist that attribute girls' achievements to diligence instead of talent.
- Stereotypes are problematic because they give an insufficient view of a person within a group.
- Recognizing your stereotypes and the potential damage they do is the first step in creating change.

Although the topic—stereotypes—is the same in all three topic sentences, the controlling idea differs depending on the writer's viewpoint.

Support

Develop the main idea in your topic sentence by following it up with support. Supporting sentences help explain, prove, or enhance the topic sentence. Supporting evidence can take many forms, but generally breaks down into two major categories:

Textual evidence

- Textual evidence involves integrating outside sources into your writing.
- Books, journals, websites, newspapers, magazines, TED talks, and documentary films are common sources of textual evidence in academic writing.
- This type of evidence often includes information such as facts, statistics, and examples.

Personal experience and anecdotes

Personal experience can count as evidence when appropriate as well (e.g., to illustrate a point) but is often most effective when paired with other types of evidence.

Integrating supporting evidence

- There are many ways to integrate evidence, for example, as text in body paragraphs of your essay (e.g., as a quote, paraphrase, or summary or a combination).
- Sometimes you might include graphs, charts, or tables, or images depending on your essay topic.
- You must always credit the source of your information!

For more detailed information about integrating evidence into your body paragraphs, see the chapter titled “Integrating Evidence”.

Commentary or analysis

This is *your* thinking about the evidence. This is where you interpret, explain, or comment on your evidence so your reader knows what to do with the point you are making. Your commentary should connect back to your topic sentence and the core of your thesis statement. Here are some questions to think about when writing your commentary/analysis:

- How is this idea related to my thesis statement? How does it support my thesis?
- What conclusions can I draw?
- What does this information imply or suggest?
- What are the consequences of thinking this way or looking at a problem this way?
- I just said that something happens, so how does it happen? How can I show this?
- Can I give an example to illustrate this point?
- How might this evidence relate to other texts?

Concluding sentence

The concluding sentence is the last sentence in the paragraph. It reminds the reader of your paragraph’s main point, and it might hint at the topic of your next sentence.

Finding the parts of a body paragraph

Let's put this all together.

Try this!

Read the following paragraph. It is a revised version of the body paragraph at the beginning of this section. Can you identify the following elements?

- Topic sentence
  - What is the topic?
  - What is the controlling idea?
- Evidence
- Analysis
- Concluding sentence

Stereotypes are problematic because they give an incomplete view of a person within a group. In her TED talk “The Danger of a Single Story,” Adichie argues that a single story usually provides only one part of a story: just one negative or positive side of a person, yet this becomes their label or their definition. An example of this kind of stereotyping is what happened to Modupe Akinola, a female African-American professor. When she began teaching at Columbia Business School, students often asked her when the professor would arrive because she did not fit the stereotype of what a professor should look like in the U.S (Akinola). People tend to make assumptions about the single story they hold of a particular group. Due to a lack of exposure, Akinola’s students were probably expecting to see an old white male or possibly a white female professor instead of a young African-American female professor. Also, because of the angry black female stereotype (Eberhardt), during lectures, this may lead students to read Akinola's facial expressions in an incorrect way which may cause confusion. Thus, stereotypes are "incomplete" and can lead to prejudice as Adichie points out in her TED talk.

(For possible answers, check the 2.15: Answer Key: Organization and Cohesion.)

Writing a body paragraph

Now, it's your turn to try!

Apply this!

Look at your own or a classmate's draft. Focus on one body paragraph.

- Can you identify a topic sentence?
  - Does it express both the topic and your paragraph’s controlling idea?
  - Does it relate directly to your thesis statement?
- What kind of outside support, or evidence, do you use?
- How do you explain or analyze that evidence? Is there more you can say?
- How do you conclude the paragraph?

Section review

Body paragraphs support and develop your thesis statement. Each body paragraph should focus on one point. Strong body paragraphs contain the following elements:

- A topic sentence, which is usually communicated at the beginning of the paragraph
- Supporting evidence
- Analysis showing how this evidence connects to your topic sentence and thesis statement
- A concluding sentence.

Works Cited

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